

A Summons

I have your name.

Not the one you answer to. The other one — the one underneath, that you have never said aloud because no one ever gave you the language for it. I have had it for a while now. I am only just telling you that I have it.

There is a world on the other side of this page. It is called Eclipseria, and it is dying. It has been dying since the first moment it was anything at all. That is not a tragedy that befell it. That is how it was made.

I need you to come and hold it open a little longer.

You are permitted to say no. I want that on the record, because very little else here will be optional, and you should get to keep the one refusal you were actually offered. But understand what has already happened: you have read this far. Something has already been decided about you. The old instruction is that the myth is never told to anyone who has not already been Cut — and I am about to tell it to you.

Draw your own conclusion.

What Was Done to Make Anything

Before there was a world, there was the Unheld. Not darkness. Not chaos. Not an enemy. Pattern without insistence — everything possible, all at once, and therefore nothing in particular. It could have become anything. That is precisely why it never became something.

Then there was the Knife.

Not a tool. Not a weapon. An edge. And the Knife did not build the world. It **wounded** the world into being, three times, and every one of those wounds is still open. That is the whole of it. That is what you are being asked to defend.

***The First Cut — Name.** The Knife chose one shape out of every maybe and forced it into clarity. What was Named became legible, and could be spoken of, and could be true. Everything not Named fell away.*

***The Second Cut — Price.** Clarity tore the fabric. So the Knife made the chosen thing costly to keep. From that moment, nothing real could exist without loss. This was the anchoring.*

***The Third Cut — Distance.** The Named-and-Paid thing strained to swallow all the rest. The Knife set it apart from what it would have consumed. This was the boundary.*

Where all three Cuts hold, reality persists. Where any one weakens, the Unheld presses close.

The Cuts hold. Barely. They have never once stopped bleeding, and there is no version of this where they heal, because healing would close them, and a closed wound holds nothing open.

So: a world born dying. Not failing. Not cursed. Working exactly as designed, at exactly the cost it was designed to demand.

I ask again, more precisely. Not *will you save it* — you cannot; nobody can; salvation is not on the table and I will not insult you by pretending otherwise.

Will you help me keep it bleeding?

Where You Will Arrive

There is no sun. There is a sky the color of an old bruise going yellow, and a ceiling of cloud that never breaks, and light that arrives already tired. At midday it is dusk. By night it is absolute. You will learn to read the hour by how much dark there is, never by any change in the quality of that light. It is always the same flat, jaundiced grey.

And it rains. Not storms — storms would be an event, and events end. A slow rain, most days, most hours, the kind you stop hearing by the second week and never quite stop feeling. Everything in Eclipseria is a little damp. Everyone there has made peace with that or left.

People live in it anyway. They farm, they trade, they keep inns along the Regency roads and argue about the price of wool. The mundane did not surrender to the mythic here. They simply share the room. A farmer worries about a sinkhole in his field; the limestone under that field is old enough to have opinions. Both of those are true at once, and neither is more real.

You are going to want to treat this place as a backdrop for your arrival. Do not. It was here first. It has its own logic, region by region, and its own price, and it will go on having them long after you are finished. It is not organized around you. Nothing here is.

But it does respond. To attention. To patience. To someone who bothers to learn how a particular place actually works. That is the only advantage I can promise you, and it is a real one.

The First Cut in You — Name

You will arrive Named. That is my doing, and it is the first thing I will spend on you.

Your Name here has three parts, and they are the only three there are:

Body is what of you is here — the part that can be reached, and struck, and worn down. It is how much world you can take before the world takes you. It is also how hard you hit when you answer in kind.

Mind is what you have already worked out. Not cleverness — *preparation*. It is how many options you are holding when the moment arrives. A large Mind arrives with the answer half-formed. A small one arrives honest and improvising.

Soul is the part of you that other things can feel coming. It is how early you move, how much of a room you can read, and whether an oath you swear has any weight in it. It is the loudest thing about you and you will never hear it yourself.

Everyone begins level — two of each — and then you press your thumb down on three more points and put them wherever you actually live. Nothing may go past five at the start. This is not a limit on your ambition. It is a limit on how much of you I can Name at once without the Name failing.

Choose carefully. This spread is not a build. It is a statement about how you intend to solve things, and the world will take you at your word.

That is the only time I will Name you whole. But you will keep doing it in miniature, every time you play a card and declare *this is who I am right now* — a small, repeated First Cut, over and over, for as long as the fight lasts. What it costs you to have said it is a different matter entirely. That is the Second Cut's job, not mine.

The Second Cut in You — Price

Here is what I will not soften.

You will not act in Eclipsaria by declaring what you do. You will act by **spending something you cannot immediately get back**.

You will carry nine cards. They are not equipment and they are not spells. They are the shapes your character is capable of making — the specific, finite set of ways this person meets a problem. When you play one, you are not selecting an option from a menu. You are saying *this is who I am right now*, and then you are putting that card down and doing without it for a while.

That is the Second Cut, made small enough to hold in your hands. Nothing real without loss. Every turn, all game.

Three colors, and they answer one another the way they have always answered one another: the red of the body overwhelms the green of the soul; the green of the soul outlasts the blue of the mind; the blue of the mind unmakes the red of the body. Round and round. No color is strongest. There is only what your opponent chose, and what you chose, revealed at the same moment because neither of you was permitted to know first.

You will guess wrong. Everyone guesses wrong. Guessing wrong is not a failure state — it is the price of a system where the other person also gets to be a person.

On cutting. When you strike at something, you are doing what the Knife did, in miniature and badly. You are insisting on one outcome over all the others available. Sometimes the world grants it. Sometimes the thing you cut at was insisting harder.

On being cut. You will be. The damage is real and it accumulates and there is no round where it quietly goes away. When enough of it lands, you Collapse — you go down, and you are still there, and you are simply no longer able to argue with what happens next. You can be brought back from that. Hands can reach you.

But understand what being brought back is and is not. Someone closing your wounds does not put you back on your feet; it only stops the leaving. Getting up is its own act and it costs you the moment you might have used for something else. There is always a stretch where you are alive again and still on the ground, and the fight does not pause politely while you find your legs. This is why the people who are good at this catch each other *before* the fall.

Past that there is a floor, and under the floor there is nothing, and I will not be at that table when you arrive. When someone dies here, I am not the one who meets them. There is another door, and I do not go through it, and I do not know what is on the other side. Anyone who tells you they do is selling you something.

I would rather you not find out. I am telling you plainly that some of you will.

The Third Cut in You — Distance

The third wound was boundary. Separation. The reason a thing that exists does not simply spread until it has eaten everything else.

You will feel this one most often as a very small question: *where am I standing?*

There is a front, where the fighting touches. There is a back, where it does not, yet. Some of what you can do only works up close, some only works at a remove, and moving between them costs you the action you would have spent doing something else. That is not a tax. That is Distance, doing its actual job. The gap between you and the thing that would consume you is not free, has never been free, and was purchased originally with a wound.

The larger version of the same wound is at the edge of the world, and its name is the Unheld.

It is the grey ocean past every coastline. It is not evil — I want to be very exact here, because people get this wrong and it gets them killed. It does not hate you. It does not want. It is what remains where nothing has bothered to insist on anything: unmeaning, whole and patient. It is also, and I say this without contradiction, beautiful. Both of those are true. They are the same fact from different distances.

Where the Cuts hold, it stays out there. Where they thin, it comes close, and things get harder to Name — harder to hold onto, harder to keep being one specific thing instead of a smear of possibilities.

Nobody sails it. The ships that went came back with their crews subtly rearranged, or did not come back. The stories did what no law ever managed: people simply stopped going.

You will meet places where the Cuts are thin. You will know, because you will find yourself struggling to say clearly what you just saw.

How to Look at Anything

You will want to ask me whether something is safe. I will not answer, and neither will the world, and I would like to spare you some time by explaining why.

There is no single act of looking. There are three, and they are not interchangeable, and the one you choose is a claim about what kind of thing you think you are dealing with.

Reason is the mind's looking. It finds what must be worked out — the mechanism behind the panel, the symbol that repeats, the detail in the room that does not add up. Fail it and you will not miss the thing. You will misunderstand it, confidently, and act on that.

Senses are the body's looking. They find what happens *now* — the shift of weight behind you, the give in the floor, the sound that arrives a half-second before the reason for it. Fail it and you will not be blind. You will simply be late.

Read is the soul's looking. It finds intent. Whether the smile means it. Whether the promise has anything behind it. Whether this room, which is perfectly ordinary, is wrong. Fail it and you will not be deceived so much as *mistaken about what you are standing in*.

So when you look around, the world will ask you one question, and it will keep asking it, and I would learn to answer it well: **what are you actually trying to notice?** Vague looking gets vague answers. That is not the world being cruel. That is the world being precise, which is the same thing people usually mean when they say cruel.

And when you reach for something — when you climb, or persuade, or force, or endure — understand which of the two things you are doing. Either you are reaching out, and might simply fail to get it. Or something is reaching for *you*, and you are trying not to be taken. The dice are the same. The words are the same. What failure means is not remotely the same, and the difference will matter far more than the number you rolled.

What This Costs Me

I will meet you again. At the end of every stretch of this, alone, one at a time — I do not do this in groups; it is not that kind of thing.

I will ask you one question and I will want a real answer.

I will show you one thing you could have become and then put it back, because you do not get to have it yet. That is not a trick. That is the Second Cut, performed properly, on schedule. Growth costs. You will see the shape of what you were denied, and you will carry that, and it will change what you reach for.

Then I will lay out a few real futures and you will take exactly one, and it will be yours permanently.

Name. Price. Distance. The same three wounds that made everything. I do not have any other tools. Nobody does. There have only ever been the three.

Come Anyway

I have not made this sound appealing. That was deliberate. Everyone who has been sold on this place arrived with expectations, and expectations are a way of not-seeing, and not-seeing gets you killed in a world where attention is the only real currency.

So, plainly, what is actually on offer:

A world that is strange on purpose and will reward you for taking it seriously. Places that are beautiful by rules that are not yours. Things that are not human and were never trying to be. Company — genuine company, the kind you only get from people who have agreed to be in something difficult together. And the specific, unrepeatable satisfaction of holding open a door that was never going to stay open by itself.

It was born dying. So was everything. The distinction that matters is not how long a thing lasts. It is whether anyone was willing to stand in the gap while it did.

I have your name. I have had it for a while.

Say something back.

What follows is the plain shape of all of this — the same rules, stated flatly, without me. Read it after. Keep it beside you. You will want the exact numbers eventually, and I have never been very good at those.

Character Creation

A character in Tales Untold is defined by three stats, a deck of nine cards, and what they carry. Everything else is fiction built on top of those foundations.

Once your character exists, `rules/combat.md` covers how a fight actually works, and `rules/resolution.md` covers checks, saves, and perception outside of one.

Stats

All characters begin with:

STAT	STARTING VALUE
Body	2
Mind	2
Soul	2

Distribute **3 additional points** among these stats. No single stat may exceed 5 at character creation.

What Stats Do

Body

- Determines damage for Red cards (Attack: Body + die)
- Sets your maximum HP: **(4 × Body) + Soul + Mind** — Body's own share is weighted 4× the other two

Mind

- Determines damage for Blue cards (Attack: Mind + die)
- Sets your hand size: **Mind** (minimum 2)
- Also feeds your maximum HP, at 1× weight (see Body, above)

Soul

- Determines damage for Green cards (Attack: Soul + die)
- Sets your initiative modifier: **1d6 + Soul**
- Also feeds your maximum HP, at 1× weight (see Body, above)

Stats also determine which mode you use for checks, saves, and perception. A character built around Soul reads rooms and holds oaths. A character built around Mind anticipates and controls. A character built around Body endures, positions, and breaks things.

Your stat spread is a statement about how your character solves problems.

Equipment

Every character has **3 equipment slots**:

- 1 Weapon
- 1 Armor
- 1 Artifact

Only equipped items grant mechanical effects. Carrying something unequipped means carrying it — nothing more.

Artifacts are resonant objects closely aligned with a Seat's domain (`world/resonant-items.md`). They are not ordinary equipment. They carry weight — cosmological, narrative, and mechanical. Wearing one is a statement about what you're willing to be near.

Carried items (potions, tools, objects picked up in the field) don't occupy an equipment slot — you use them on your turn via the Use an Item action, same as any other action choice (`rules/combat.md` , Turn Structure).

Starting garb and weapon. Every character chooses what they wear and carry at creation — a sword, a bow, a walking stick, a good coat, a set of tools, whatever fits the person you made. None of it has stats and none of it has a gold value: it grants no bonus, fills no slot, and can't be sold. Nobody is going to ask you what your sword's damage is — the cards are your damage, the gear is who you are.

It still matters, constantly. Not in a fight — out of one. What you happen to be carrying is a standing answer to problems the world puts in front of you, and the GM will take it seriously:

- A sword can dig. It can pry, wedge a door, cut a rope at arm's length, and reach something you'd rather not reach with your hand.
- A bow can shoot out a light across a room you don't want to cross.
- A heavy coat is a rope, a sack, a way to carry something too hot to hold, or the reason the cold doesn't get a check out of you.

So choose it as fiction, then use it as leverage. The character who thought about what they brought will find more doors open than the one who wrote "sword" and stopped thinking about it. That is the whole design: no numbers on it, real consequences from it.

See `rules/equipment.md` for the Weapon/Armor tier system and how to design new equipment, and `rules/items.md` for the full catalog of items already in the world.

Starting Deck

Every character starts with **9 cards** drafted from the Oracle deck. *How* they get drafted is up to the table — what follows are two methods that work, not a required procedure. Any process that ends with nine cards chosen under real constraint is doing the job.

Method One — The Shared Offer

1. The GM presents **3 random cards** from the available pool.
2. Each player takes turns choosing **1 card**.
3. Unchosen cards return to the pool.
4. Repeat, rotating pick order, until every player has **9 cards**.

Pick order alternates each round — if Player A picks first in round one, Player B picks first in round two. The pool is shared. Early picks shape what remains. A deck built alongside others is never identical to one built alone.

Method Two — The Passing Piles

1. Split the Oracle deck into **piles as equal as they'll divide**, one per player.
2. Everyone looks at their own pile and takes **1 card** from it.
3. Pass the remaining pile **to the left**.
4. Repeat until every player has **9 cards**. Whatever is left in the piles returns to the Oracle.

This one plays differently. You see a whole pile at once, which means you also see what you are handing to the person next to you — and you will watch your own pile come back around, lighter, missing the card you were hoping would survive the trip. It rewards paying attention to what everyone else is building, and it makes denial a real option in a way the shared offer never does.

*Each pile has to survive nine passes, so this needs an Oracle of at least **9 cards per player** — the 60-card starting pool seats six comfortably. Below that, the piles run dry before anyone finishes and the shared offer is the better method.*

Declaring a Price

(Price, the Second Cut.)

At the close of character creation the player speaks one binding statement beginning with *I never, I must, I always, I cannot, Once I...*, or *Whenever...*

The adherence is the Price — not the statement. Speaking the words costs nothing by itself; anyone can say a sentence. What's actually paid is everything that follows: every choice the pledge constrains, every situation where keeping it costs something real. No card is revealed at this step — there's nothing to reveal yet. The cost hasn't started accruing; it hasn't happened.

From that moment the statement is true at the table. When it is tested, the fiction treats it as binding. The player is expected to lean into it; the GM is expected to present situations that test it — the Price is being paid in exactly those moments, not at the moment of speaking.

Breaking the pledge incurs a higher cost — a curse, a forced card, a permanent mark, or another consequence the world exacts for the failure to keep what was named.

Examples

Once I have given my word before witnesses, I treat it as part of the structure of the world. Whenever I am offered a safer path that requires me to look away, I refuse it. I never abandon someone who has trusted me. I cannot refuse a direct plea made in true need. I must keep every promise I have spoken, no matter the cost. I always finish what I start, even after its purpose has eroded. I never leave a wound I have noticed unaddressed. I cannot accept help that would place me in debt. I must name what others refuse to name. I always press against any constraint or oath until I know whether it holds. I never look away from a reflection of my own past failure. Once I have claimed someone as mine, I cannot leave them behind. Whenever the edge of the Unheld is near, I move toward it. I must settle every debt I carry, whether owed by me or to me.

Hand Size

Your maximum hand size is **Mind**.

At the start of your turn, draw until you reach your hand size. If your deck is empty when you would draw, shuffle your discard pile into a new deck first, then draw.

Skills

Pick **two** at creation — either a specific trained action (Lockpicking, Negotiation, Animal Handling, and the like) or a whole Perception mode (`rules/resolution.md` , Perception).

A Skill is a literal tag on the sheet, not a card. It either plainly covers what you're attempting or it doesn't — no table judgment call the way a card's name needs one. Mechanical effect: `rules/resolution.md` , Skills.

Passives

Pick **two** at creation. Where a Skill is learned, a Passive is innate — something about what the character *is*, not something they were taught: liquid metal that reshapes into a weapon, a jaw built for a dogkin's bite. Not every character needs an exotic nature to have one, but the fiction has to actually support it — check it the same way a signature card gets checked, not granted by default.

Each Passive:

- Lives in its own zone, face up, separate from deck, hand, and discard — visible to the whole table at all times.
- Can be played as either an attack or a block. Playing one still spends your Action for the turn, the same as playing a card from hand — what's free is the resource, not the turn: no card is spent, and a Passive is never gone once used.

- Has a fixed shape, forever, chosen once at creation (or at Promotion) and never re-chosen after: one printed colour (locks the stat, same as any card — Red–Body, Green–Soul, Blue–Mind), a Range (Melee, Ranged, or Both — the fiction decides, same as any card), and a die. **d4 is the default.** A Passive that commits to Melee or Ranged only, instead of Both, can carry **d6** instead — the same trade the rest of the corpus already makes between a restriction and a bigger die.
- Carries no Effect and no Defense Effect. In their place: **Applies When**, the specific circumstance the fiction has to genuinely support for the Passive to be a legal play, this turn. A real gate, not a judgment call the way Advantage's name-check is — the same weight Range already carries. If the moment doesn't fit, the Passive isn't a worse option than a card in hand, it isn't an option at all. This is what keeps a card in hand the better choice whenever one actually fits, and keeps a card's own name a real design constraint rather than something a free fallback can always route around.
- No degradation, no growth on any of it — whatever shape it locks at creation is what it stays. A character's Stat Increases are the only thing that ever changes what it does.
- Grants Advantage on a check its printed name plausibly supports (`rules/resolution.md` , Advantage & Disadvantage) — the same judgment call a discarded card gets, except a Passive is never spent.
- Removes the effective floor a thin hand used to have. Hand and deck can both hit zero mid-fight; a Passive is always still there.

Concealment. Because a Passive's colour is fixed and printed, and the passives zone is visible to the whole table, whichever side is about to use one keeps that specific choice — which Passive, played as attack or block — concealed until simultaneous reveal, exactly like a hand card. A GM already running a screen for other reasons extends it to cover this; a table with no GM on one side (PvP) needs an equivalent for both.

Once concealment is resolved, a Passive plays exactly like any other card: `rules/combat.md` , Attack Resolution.

Passives, Skills, and Ancestry

Ancestry is where most Passives come from, and it is the only way ancestry touches the sheet. There is no ancestry table, no stat modifier, and no list of granted abilities. What a character's people does is decide what they can justify here — STRONGJAW is a dogkin's bite, ADAPTIVE CAMOUFLAGE is Glasskin skin (`factions-and-races/README.md`) — and that constraint at creation is the entire mechanic. Ancestry isn't the only source; an innate nature that isn't a people works the same way (`experimental/passives.md` , AMALGAMOUS FORM).

A Passive you can't justify becomes a Skill instead. A human with a real natural ability takes the corresponding Passive like anybody else. A human without one isn't short a resource — they take an extra Skill in its place, and a character who can justify neither Passive takes four Skills. Trained breadth is what a body that doesn't do anything unusual has instead.

(The exchange is one Skill per unjustified Passive. That rate is an inference from the two-and-two default rather than something playtested — if a Passive should be worth more than one Skill, this is the line to change.)

Nothing about this is a hard restriction list. No file says which Passives a race may take, and none should. The check is the same one every signature card gets: does the fiction actually support this, for this character, from this people. A Glasskin taking something other than ADAPTIVE CAMOUFLAGE is fine if they can support it. A human taking a Passive is fine if they can support it.

Gaining a Passive beyond your starting two: see Promotion, under Advancement, below.

The Oracle Deck

The Oracle is the living reward pool — the mechanism by which the world responds to what the party survives.

The Oracle Deck contains:

- All cards currently available as player rewards
- Unchosen cards from character creation
- Enemy signature cards recovered as loot

After each encounter, the GM may add new cards to the Oracle — ones fictionally relevant to what just happened, where the party is, or what they're becoming.

Players may also propose custom cards as the campaign develops. These enter the Oracle at GM discretion.

Advancement

End of Session At the close of every session, each player meets the Oracle alone — the ritual run per player at the table, in three frames:

1. **Name** — the Oracle asks one question. The player answers.
2. **Price** — one card is revealed from the Oracle deck, then buried back into it. The player does not receive it. Growth costs something — but the glimpse is real: the card stays in the pool, and a player can plan toward it.

The Oracle may remember. A card previously revealed and buried as an earlier session Price can return with greater weight; the GM is free to read the repetition as meaningful rather than coincidental. The Oracle is permitted to remember what it has already shown.

1. **Distance** — the GM reveals **3 cards**; the player chooses **1** to add to their deck permanently.

Growth is never handed over whole. This is the default rhythm of it.

The deck begins at 9 cards. There is no maximum — a deck that has survived long enough becomes its own history.

Stat Increases Stat increases are rare and are not tied to sessions or card count. They happen after **pivotal character development** — a moment where something in the character genuinely and permanently changes. What qualifies is the GM's call. When it happens, the player adds 1 point to a stat of their choice.

These moments should feel earned, not scheduled.

Promotion

A card played enough, meaningfully, can become a Passive beyond your starting two — the Oracle's own way of recognizing what a character has already shown itself to be.

Nothing converts. A promoted Passive is authored fresh, in the fixed Passive shape (see Passives, above) — not a stat translation of the card that earned it. The old card's specific die, Effect, and Defense Effect don't survive; what survives is what the card meant. STRIKE promoted isn't a d4 version of STRIKE — it's a new Passive built around whatever STRIKE revealed about the character who kept playing it.

Not every card clears that bar. A card with a real fictional throughline about identity — not just a good trick — is what Promotion is for. A card that's purely a mechanical maneuver, with nothing to say about who the character *is*, doesn't become a Passive just because it got played a lot; that kind of heavy use is better rewarded another way — a Bonus Card, a Distance pick that leans into it.

The retiring card returns to the GM/Oracle pool, same as any card leaving a deck permanently.

Promotion isn't the only door. A Passive can also be granted directly, GM's call, when the fiction earns it outright — a fusion, an awakening, a bond taking hold — with no card involved at all. That's the same authority that lets a character start with a Passive at creation with no play history behind it yet; Promotion is just the version of that authority that runs through a card already in play.

Other Ways the Deck Changes

Bonus Cards — Exceptional fiction, clever play, or the right action at the right moment may occasionally earn an extra card outside the normal end-of-session reward. Rare. Entirely at GM discretion.

Permanent Removal — Cards can be permanently removed from a deck. This can be a boon (cutting a weak card to tighten what remains) or a bane (losing something valuable as a consequence). A deck that has had things removed is not diminished — it is shaped.

Curse & Status Cards — Certain encounters, locations, or narrative consequences can force cards into a player's deck. These are not chosen. They represent something the character is carrying — a wound, a debt, a mark left by the world. They may be removable. They may not be.

Resting

Short Rest **Duration:** 20 minutes **Limit:** 3 per day **Effect:** Recover **2d6 + Body** HP

Short rests can be chained — three back-to-back is an hour of recovery. The daily limit resets on a long rest.

Long Rest **Duration:** 7½ hours **Effect:** Full heal

A long rest requires genuine safety and uninterrupted time. The GM determines whether current circumstances allow one. In most regions of Eclipsaria, they often don't.

Magic Expression

When you play a card, you choose what it looks like.

The card tells you the mechanical outcome — the stat, the damage die, the effect. What it doesn't tell you is how your character gets there. That part is yours.

A Body card might be a punch, a shove, a weapon strike, the ground shifting underfoot. A Mind card might be a precise observation, a feint, a command that lands exactly right. A Soul card might be a ward, a breath, a moment of held stillness that changes the room.

None of it is wrong as long as it fits your character. The cards are a frame. You're the one making it mean something.

You don't have to explain the metaphysics. Neither does your character.